V E L A

PRIVATE COMMAND INFRASTRUCTURE

Anthropic API Key Setup Guide

How to create your Anthropic Console account, add billing, and generate your API key.
This is not your Claude.ai account — it is a separate account.

Your judgment. Our infrastructure.

Pre-Installation · Takes about 10 minutes · March 2026

> Important: this is NOT your Claude.ai account. Claude.ai is the consumer chat interface at claude.ai. What you need here is a separate developer account at console.anthropic.com. These are two different accounts, even if you use the same email address for both.

Hannah runs on Claude Sonnet — Anthropic's AI model. She uses your Anthropic Console account to make API calls. Every interaction Hannah has with the AI model costs a small amount, billed directly to your Anthropic account. Typical cost is $3–15 per day depending on how heavily you use the system.

By the end of this guide you will have three things:

What	Looks Like	Where to Store It
Anthropic Console account	Account at console.anthropic.com	Use your primary email
Billing configured	Credit card added, monthly limit set	Confirm in billing settings
API Key	sk-ant-api03-... (long string)	Password manager — shown only once

1 Create Your Anthropic Console Account

3 minutes

1 Go to the Anthropic Console

Open a browser and go to this exact address — not claude.ai:

→ **console.anthropic.com**

2 Create your account

Look for the Sign Up or Create Account button. The page may also offer to sign in with Google.

→ **Click Sign Up**

You can sign up with an email address and password, or use Sign in with Google if you want to use your Gmail account. Either works.

3 Verify your email

If you signed up with email, Anthropic sends you a verification email. Open it and click the verification link.

→ **Open your email → Click the verification link → Return to console.anthropic.com**

4	**Complete account setup** Anthropic may ask a few setup questions — your name, how you plan to use the API, your organization. Fill these in honestly. For organization, you can put your company name or your own name. → **Fill in the fields → Click Continue**

You are now in the Anthropic Console dashboard. It looks like a dark interface with a sidebar on the left.

2 Add Billing

3 minutes — your API key will not work without this

Your API key will not work until you add a credit card. This is a hard requirement from Anthropic — not something your installer can work around. Do this before the installation call.

5	**Go to the Billing page** Look at the left sidebar of the console. Near the bottom, you will see your account name or a settings icon. → **Click Settings in the left sidebar**

A settings page opens. Look for a Billing tab or section.

→ **Click Billing**

6	**Add a payment method** On the Billing page, look for a button that says Add Payment Method or Add Credit Card. → **Click Add Payment Method**

A form appears asking for your credit card details. Fill in your card number, expiration date, CVC, and billing address.

→ **Click Save or Add Card**

Your card is now on file.

7	**Set a monthly spending limit** This protects you from unexpected charges. On the Billing page, look for a section called Spend Limits, Usage Limits, or Monthly Budget. → **Click on the spend limit field or Edit button**

Set your monthly limit to $100 or $200 to start. You can always increase it later once you understand your

usage patterns. Typical VELA usage is $90–450 per month depending on how actively you use it.

→ Type: 100 → Click Save

You will receive email alerts when you approach this limit.

A $100 monthly limit is a safety net, not a ceiling. If you hit it mid-month, Hannah will stop working until you either increase the limit or the month resets. Start at $200 if you plan to use VELA heavily.

3 Generate Your API Key

3 minutes — the most important step

The API key is the credential Hannah uses to access the AI model. It is shown to you exactly once — when you create it. If you lose it, you cannot retrieve it. You must create a new one.

8 Go to the API Keys page

Look at the left sidebar of the console. You will see a menu item called API Keys.

→ **Click API Keys in the left sidebar**

You land on a page showing your existing API keys (probably empty right now) and a button to create a new one.

9 Create a new API key

Look for a button near the top-right of the page that says Create Key or + New Key.

→ **Click Create Key**

10 Name your key

A dialog box appears asking for a name for this key. Give it a descriptive name so you know what it is for.

→ **Type: VELA → Click Create Key**

11 Copy your API key — this is the critical step

Your API key appears on screen. It looks like this:

API Key:	`sk-ant-api03-xxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxx`

→ **Click the Copy button next to the key — do this immediately**

This key is shown to you exactly ONCE. The moment you close this dialog or navigate away, the full key is hidden forever. If you miss this, you must delete the key and create a new one.

12	**Save the key in your password manager right now** Open your password manager (1Password, Bitwarden, Apple Keychain, or wherever you store passwords). Create a new entry.

Field	What to Enter
Name / Title	VELA Anthropic API Key
Username / Account	Your Anthropic Console email address
Password / Secret	Paste your API key here (sk-ant-api03-...)
Website	console.anthropic.com
Notes	Created for VELA installation — do not share

→ **Save the entry in your password manager**

Then return to the Anthropic Console and click Done to close the key dialog.

4 Verify Everything Is Ready

1 minute

13 Confirm your key appears in the list

After closing the dialog, you should see your VELA key listed on the API Keys page. It shows the key name, when it was created, and the first few characters of the key.

→ **Confirm VELA appears in the API Keys list**

The key will show something like sk-ant-...XXXX with only the last few characters visible. This is normal — the full key is stored in your password manager.

14 Confirm billing is active

Click Billing in the left sidebar one more time.

→ **Click Billing**

You should see your credit card listed and your monthly spending limit set. If either is missing, go back and complete that step before the installation call.

15 Make a note of the difference between your two Anthropic accounts

Many people have both a Claude.ai account and an Anthropic Console account using the same email address. They are completely separate.

Account	Website	What It Is	What You Need It For
Claude.ai	claude.ai	Consumer chat interface — like a website you browse	Personal use — not for VELA
Anthropic Console	console.anthropic.com	Developer API account — where your API key lives	VELA — this is the one you just set up

✓ You're Done — Final Checklist

Before your installation call, confirm you have all of these:

- ☐ Anthropic Console account created at console.anthropic.com (not claude.ai)
- ☐ Email verified
- ☐ Credit card added to billing
- ☐ Monthly spending limit set ($100–200 recommended)
- ☐ API key created and named VELA
- ☐ API key saved in password manager — full key starting with sk-ant-api03-

Bring your API key (from your password manager) to the installation call. Your installer will enter it into the system. You will not need to go back to the Anthropic Console again unless something changes.

greg@gregshindler.com · 202-439-5834 · Telegram: @Vela_Greg

? Common Problems

If you see this...	Do this
I already have a Claude.ai account — do I need a new one?	Yes. Claude.ai and console.anthropic.com are separate systems. You can use the same email address, but you need to create an account specifically at console.anthropic.com.
I closed the key dialog before copying the key	Go to API Keys, find your VELA key, click the three dots or delete icon, delete it, and create a new one. There is no way to retrieve a key after the creation dialog closes.
My API key doesn't start with sk-ant-api03-	Older API keys may start with sk-ant- followed by different characters. Any key that starts with sk-ant- is valid. Copy the entire string.
I can't find the Billing page	Look in the left sidebar for Settings. Billing is usually a tab within Settings. If you see a different layout, look for any mention of Payment or Usage.
Anthropic says my key is invalid during the install	Confirm the key in your password manager starts with sk-ant- and has no extra spaces before or after it. Then confirm your billing is active — keys do not work without an active payment method.
I hit my spending limit mid-month	Go to console.anthropic.com → Settings → Billing → Edit your monthly limit and increase it. Hannah will resume working within a few minutes.